SCAM DECODED · SETUP GUIDE

Protect Your Parents

The step-by-step setup guide: the conversation, every setting on their phone and accounts, and word-for-word scripts for the 10 calls scammers make most.

- A three-visit plan that fits a holiday or a weekend
- 40+ setup checks for phone, email, bank, credit and computer
- 10 phone scripts your parent can read straight from the page
- What to do, and say, if money has already gone

General education, not legal or financial advice. Settings and phone numbers checked November 2026; menus change, so follow the current wording on the device. All example calls, names and numbers are fictional. © Scam Decoded.

START HERE

How to use this guide

You don't need to be good with technology, and neither do they. You need three visits, this guide, and their permission.

Visit 1 · The conversation (30 minutes)

Pages 4–5. Talk, don't fix anything yet. Agree on a family safe word and the call-back rule. Fill in the Family Plan (page 15).

Visit 2 · The setup (60–90 minutes)

Pages 6–9. Work through the checklists together, on their devices, with them holding the phone. Tick as you go.

Visit 3 · Practice and check-in (20 minutes, a week later)

Pages 10–14. Read two scripts out loud together. Put the phone-side card (page 19) by their phone. Book a monthly 10-minute check-in (page 18).

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Already have our Family Scam-Proofing Kit? This guide goes deeper on parents: the settings, the scripts and the follow-up. The kit's fridge card and wallet cards work alongside it.

BEFORE YOU START

Why parents are targeted

Older adults report losing more money per scam than any other age group, according to the FTC and the FBI. That's not because they're gullible. It's because of what scammers can count on.

They answer the phone. Many grew up when a ringing phone meant someone you knew. Scammers rely on calls far more with older targets.

They have savings. Retirement accounts, home equity and steady income make them worth months of a scammer's time.

They're polite. Hanging up on someone feels rude. Scammers use that, and get angry or upset to keep them on the line.

They may be alone. Widowed, retired or far from family, so there's no one in the room to say "wait, that sounds off".

Every scam has the same three tells

Rush. "Right now, or else." **Secrecy.** "Don't tell your bank, or your kids." **A strange way to pay.** Gift cards, wires, crypto, cash in the mail, a Bitcoin ATM, a payment app to a stranger.

Teach these three before anything else. Two of the three means stop, hang up, and call someone they trust. Every script in this guide comes back to them.

The goal isn't to scare them

Fear makes people avoid the subject, and shame makes them hide it when something goes wrong. The goal is a plan they feel in charge of, and a family where telling someone about a strange call is normal, not embarrassing.

Ask permission. These are their devices and their money. Say "would it be OK if we set a few things up together?", not "I need your phone". Do every step with them, not for them, so they know what changed and why.

VISIT 1

The conversation

Thirty minutes over coffee. Your only job today is to talk and agree on three things.

Open with a story, not a warning

> "I saw something about a scam where they clone a grandkid's voice and call asking for bail money. It's scary how real it sounds. Has anyone ever called you with something like that?"
>
> "A friend's mom got a call from 'her bank' last month. They nearly moved her savings. Can I show you how it worked?"

Then listen. Most parents have a story of their own, a strange call or text they weren't sure about. Ask about it. That story is your way in.

Don't say

- "You'd fall for anything." (Shame shuts the conversation down.)
- "You need to stop answering the phone." (Unrealistic, and it sounds like a rule being imposed.)
- "Give me your passwords." (It's their account. Set things up together instead.)

Do say

- "These people are professionals. They fool bankers and police officers."
- "I'd want you to call me if I ever got a call like that. I'd rather be bothered 100 times than miss once."
- "Let's make a plan, so if it ever happens, we both know exactly what to do."

Agree on three things

1. **A family safe word**, said out loud, never texted or posted. Anyone calling in a panic about money must say it.
2. **The call-back rule.** Any call about money, from anyone, gets hung up on and called back on a number they look up themselves.
3. **A trusted person** they'll call before paying anyone they didn't plan to pay. That's probably you.

VISIT 1

When they push back

Some parents will brush it off. That's normal. Here's what to say to the most common responses.

They say	You say
"I'd never fall for that."	"I hope not, but these people practise all day. It's like a seatbelt. You don't plan to crash."
"I don't have anything worth stealing."	"They're after your Social Security number and your bank login as much as your savings. They can borrow in your name."
"I don't want to bother you."	"You're not bothering me. A two-minute call is nothing compared to cleaning up after a scam."
"This is too complicated."	"I'll do it with you, one thing at a time. Today we're only picking a safe word."
"You think I'm losing it."	"Not at all. I'm doing the same thing on my phone. They target everyone, and they're getting better."
"I already know about scams."	"Great, then you can help me check I've got it right." (Let them teach you.)

Make it mutual. Set up your own safe word, freeze your own credit, and turn on your own alerts in the same visit. It stops feeling like a test and starts feeling like a family project.

If they've already been scammed

They may tell you during this conversation. Your first words matter more than anything else in this guide:

> "Thank you for telling me. It's not your fault. These are professionals. Let's deal with it together."

Then go to page 17. If they're still in contact with the scammer, don't confront them by phone together. Make the calls to the bank first.

VISIT 2 · SETUP 1 OF 4

Their phone

Most scams start with a call or a text. These settings cut the volume and buy them a pause.

Calls

- [ ] **Add their real contacts first**: family, doctors, pharmacy, bank, neighbours. Filters rely on the contact list.
- [ ] **Silence or screen unknown callers.** iPhone: Settings → Phone (or Apps → Phone) → Silence or Screen Unknown Callers. Android: Phone app → Settings → Caller ID & spam / Call screen. Names vary by model.
- [ ] **Turn on spam call filtering** in the phone settings and install your carrier's free spam-blocking app if it has one.
- [ ] **Set up voicemail** with a greeting, so real callers can leave a message when unknown numbers go there.
- [ ] **Register on the Do Not Call list** (DoNotCall.gov or 1-888-382-1222). Scammers ignore it, but it cuts legitimate sales calls, so what's left is more obviously suspicious.

Texts and messages

- [ ] **Filter unknown senders** into a separate list (iPhone: Messages settings; Android: Messages → Spam protection).
- [ ] **Show them how to forward scam texts to 7726** (SPAM), then delete.
- [ ] **Agree:** no tapping links in texts about money, packages, tolls or accounts. Open the app or website directly instead.

The phone itself

- [ ] **Screen lock** with a PIN, fingerprint or face unlock.
- [ ] **Automatic updates on** for the phone and apps.
- [ ] **Carrier account PIN and number lock** (port-out or SIM protection), set by calling the carrier or in their app, so nobody can move their number.
- [ ] **Emergency contact and Medical ID** visible from the lock screen.
- [ ] **Your number in Favourites**, so calling you is one tap.
- [ ] **Remove apps they don't recognise**, especially remote-access apps (AnyDesk, TeamViewer, "QuickSupport") a "support agent" may have asked them to install.

VISIT 2 · SETUP 2 OF 4

Their accounts

Email is the master key: it resets every other password. Start there.

Email

- [ ] **A long, unique password** (a short sentence works) that isn't used anywhere else.
- [ ] **Two-step sign-in**, ideally a passkey or authenticator app rather than text codes.
- [ ] **Recovery phone and email** up to date. Add yours as a recovery contact if they're comfortable.
- [ ] **Check forwarding rules and signed-in devices.** Scammers who got in once often set up silent forwarding.

Passwords

- [ ] **A password manager** if they'll use one. If not, a **written password book** kept at home, not in a wallet, is far safer than reusing one password.
- [ ] **Change reused passwords** on bank, email and phone carrier first.
- [ ] **Teach the code rule:** "Never read a one-time code to anyone who called or texted you. Not the bank, not support, not me."

Government accounts

- [ ] **Create their my Social Security account** at SSA.gov, so nobody else can create one in their name and redirect benefits.
- [ ] **Medicare.gov account** to check claims for services they never had.
- [ ] **IRS Identity Protection PIN** through their IRS online account each January, so nobody can file a tax return in their name.

Social media

- [ ] **Make friend lists and birthdays private.** Grandparent scams use them to sound convincing.
- [ ] **Agree:** no investments, romance or "you won" offers from people met online. Ever.

VISIT 2 · SETUP 3 OF 4

Their money and credit

These steps don't stop every scam, but they make losses smaller and get them noticed faster.

Bank and cards

- [ ] **Transaction alerts** for every purchase and transfer, by text or app. Add yourself as a second alert contact only if they want that.
- [ ] **Add a trusted contact** at their bank and brokerage. Brokerages must ask for one (FINRA Rule 4512), and many banks offer it. A trusted contact can be told if fraud is suspected, but can't move money.
- [ ] **Lower daily limits** on transfers, cash withdrawals and payment apps if they rarely use them.
- [ ] **Write the fraud number** from the back of each card on the Important Numbers sheet (page 16).
- [ ] **Talk about payment apps.** Agree they're only for people they know in person.

Credit

- [ ] **Freeze their credit** at Equifax, Experian and TransUnion. Free, doesn't affect their score, and blocks most new-account fraud. Save the logins or PINs on page 16.
- [ ] **Bonus freezes:** NCTUE (utility and phone accounts) and ChexSystems (bank accounts).
- [ ] **Opt out of pre-screened credit offers** at OptOutPrescreen.com or 1-888-5-OPT-OUT, so fewer card offers sit in the mailbox.
- [ ] **Check their free credit reports** at AnnualCreditReport.com together, and look for accounts they don't recognise.

Paperwork and mail

- [ ] **A shredder** for statements, pre-approved offers and medical papers.
- [ ] **Medicare card:** remind them Medicare won't call to sell plans or "issue a new card". Only give the number to their own doctors and pharmacy.
- [ ] **Optional, with care:** discuss a financial power of attorney with a lawyer, while everyone is well. It's easier to set up before it's needed.

VISIT 2 · SETUP 4 OF 4

Their computer and tablet

The big risk here is the fake warning: a pop-up, an email or a search ad that leads to a phone call with a "technician".

- [ ] **Automatic updates on** for the operating system and browser.
- [ ] **Built-in security on** (Windows Security on Windows; Mac's built-in protections). They don't need to pay for antivirus they're pressured into.
- [ ] **Bookmarks for the sites they use**: bank, email, pharmacy, Medicare, Social Security. Teach "use the bookmark, not search or email links".
- [ ] **Remove remote-access programs** they didn't choose, and any browser extensions they don't recognise.
- [ ] **A standard (non-admin) account** for daily use, if you're comfortable setting it up, so installing software takes an extra step.
- [ ] **Back up photos and documents** to cloud storage or a drive, so "your files are locked" threats lose their power.

The pop-up rule

> A warning with a phone number on it is never real. Don't call. Close the browser. If it won't close, hold the power button to turn the computer off.

The real support rule

Real companies don't call you first about a virus, and never ask for gift cards or for you to log in to your bank while they watch. If they need help, they call **you** (or the number on the product's own website, typed in), never a number from a pop-up, email or search ad.

Practice it once

Show them how to close a browser that won't close, on their own computer. Doing it once while calm makes it much easier when the screen is flashing and a voice is saying their files will be deleted.

End of Visit 2: tick back through pages 6–9. Anything left undone, write it on the check-in tracker (page 18) so it doesn't get forgotten.

VISIT 3 · PHONE SCRIPTS

10 scripts for the calls scammers make most

Read two out loud together, one of you as the scammer. Having the words ready is what makes hanging up feel possible.

1 · "Grandma, it's me. I'm in trouble."

THEY SAY A grandchild's voice (possibly AI-cloned), crying: an accident, an arrest, a hospital. Then a "lawyer" or "officer" asks for bail money, often cash collected by a courier or gift cards. "Don't tell Mom."

YOU SAY **"What's our family word?" If there's no word: "I love you. I'm going to call you right back."**

THEN Hang up. Call the grandchild on their own number, then their parent. Never hand cash to a courier.

2 · "This is your bank's fraud department."

THEY SAY "We've stopped a suspicious charge. To protect your money we need to move it to a safe account," or "Read me the code we just sent you." Caller ID may show the bank's real name.

YOU SAY **"Thank you. I'll call the number on the back of my card."**

THEN Hang up and call that number. No real bank moves money to "keep it safe" or asks for a code.

3 · "Your computer has a virus."

THEY SAY A call or pop-up from "Microsoft", "Apple" or "your internet company": your computer is infected, let us connect to fix it. Later: "We refunded too much, please send back the difference."

YOU SAY **"I don't take support calls I didn't ask for. Goodbye."**

THEN Hang up or close the browser. Never let anyone connect to the computer who contacted you first.

PHONE SCRIPTS

4 · "This is Medicare" or "Social Security"

THEY SAY "Your Medicare card is expiring, we need to verify your number," or "There's a problem with your Social Security number. Your benefits will be suspended."

YOU SAY **"I'll call Medicare myself. Goodbye."**

THEN Call 1-800-MEDICARE or Social Security at 1-800-772-1213 if worried. They don't call to threaten or sell plans.

5 · "This is the IRS" (or the police, or the court)

THEY SAY "You owe back taxes. Pay today with gift cards or a wire, or an officer will arrest you." Or: "You missed jury duty, pay the fine now."

YOU SAY **"Send me a letter. Goodbye."**

THEN Hang up. The IRS and courts send letters and never take gift cards. Report at TIGTA.gov or ReportFraud.ftc.gov.

6 · "You've won!"

THEY SAY A lottery, sweepstakes or car. "Just pay taxes and shipping first." Sometimes a foreign lottery they never entered.

YOU SAY **"If I won, take the fees out of the prize. Goodbye."**

THEN Hang up. Real prizes never charge you to collect them.

7 · "We're cutting off your power today."

THEY SAY "Your electricity or water will be shut off in 30 minutes unless you pay now," by gift card, payment app or a Bitcoin ATM.

YOU SAY **"I'll call the number on my bill."**

THEN Hang up and call the number on a real bill. Utilities send notices first and don't take gift cards.

PHONE SCRIPTS

8 · The new friend who needs money

THEY SAY	Someone met online (often months ago, often overseas: a soldier, an engineer, a doctor) has an emergency: a flight home, customs fees, a medical bill. Or an investment "we can do together".
YOU SAY	**"I don't send money to anyone I haven't met in person."**
THEN	Tell your trusted person. Look at their photos together with a reverse image search.

9 · The package, toll or account text

THEY SAY	"Your package couldn't be delivered," "Unpaid toll: $3.95," "Your account is locked," with a link.
YOU SAY	**Nothing. Don't reply, not even "STOP".**
THEN	Forward to 7726 and delete. Check the real app or website, typed in, if unsure.

10 · "We're calling about a charity / a refund / your warranty"

THEY SAY	"Thank you for last year's donation, can we count on you again?" or "You're owed a refund" or "Your car warranty is expiring." Friendly, then pushy.
YOU SAY	**"I don't give or buy over the phone. Please send me something in writing."**
THEN	Look up the charity or company yourself and give or buy on its own website.

THE UNIVERSAL SCRIPT

"I don't make decisions about money on the phone. I'll call you back on a number I look up myself."

Then hang up, even if it feels rude. Real people are fine with it. Scammers get angry. That's the tell.

SCRIPTS FOR YOU

When you need to make the calls

If something has happened, you may be the one on the phone with their bank or a family member. Use these.

Calling their bank together

SAY **"I'm here with my mother, who's the account holder. She's been the victim of a scam and authorises me to help on this call. We need to stop a payment, check for other transactions, and change her online banking access."**

ASK "Can you flag the account for fraud? Can you recall the wire or transfer? What's the claim or reference number?" Write it down on page 16.

Talking to a sibling who doesn't think it's a problem

SAY **"I'm not saying Mom can't manage. I'm saying these people are professionals, and a safe word and a few settings cost us nothing. Can you be her second call if she can't reach me?"**

When they're still talking to the scammer

SAY **"I believe that they care about you. Can we just check one thing together?" Then use the questions: "Have you met in person? Have they asked for money?"**

AVOID Ultimatums. "It's me or them" pushes people toward the scammer, who has spent months warning them about family.

Calling the Elder Fraud Hotline

NUMBER 1-833-FRAUD-11 (1-833-372-8311), run by the US Department of Justice for people 60 and older. Case managers help with reporting and next steps.

VISIT 3

Practice, the easy way

Rehearsal is what turns a rule into a reflex. Keep it light, five minutes, and swap roles.

1. **You play the scammer.** Pick script 1 or 2. Be pushy and emotional. Your parent's only job is to say their line and hang up.
2. **Swap.** They play the scammer, you hang up. People remember the tricks better when they've said them.
3. **Ask:** "Which bit felt hardest?" Usually it's hanging up on someone crying. Agree it's always OK.
4. **Put the phone-side card (page 19)** next to the phone they use most, and the safe word somewhere only family knows.

Questions to check it's stuck

Ask	Good answer
"Someone from the bank says move your money to a safe account. What do you do?"	"Hang up, call the number on my card."
"Who would you call before paying someone you didn't plan to pay?"	"You." (or their trusted person)
"What's our safe word for?"	"Anyone calling in a panic about money has to say it."
"A pop-up says call this number. What do you do?"	"Close it. Never call."
"Someone asks you to read them a code."	"Never. Not to anyone who called me."

Praise the catch. When they tell you about a scam call they hung up on, make a big deal of it. That's the habit you want: telling someone.

FILL IN · KEEP AT HOME

Our Family Plan

Fill this in together during Visit 1. Keep it somewhere private, not on the fridge.

Our safe word (say it, never text it)	
Trusted person #1 · phone	
Trusted person #2 · phone	
Date we agreed this plan	

Our rules

1. Any call about money: hang up and call back on a number we look up ourselves.
2. We never pay with gift cards, wires, crypto, Bitcoin ATMs, cash by courier or mail, or payment apps to strangers.
3. We never read a one-time code to anyone who contacted us.
4. Before paying anyone we didn't plan to pay, we call our trusted person.
5. If something happens, we tell each other. Nobody gets blamed.

Signed (optional, but it helps)

_____ _____

FILL IN · KEEP AT HOME

Important Numbers

The real numbers, written down before anyone needs them. Scammers rely on people searching in a panic.

Who	Number / login hint
Bank fraud line (back of card)	
Credit card fraud line	
Second card / bank	
Phone carrier (and account PIN hint)	
Equifax / Experian / TransUnion freeze logins (where kept)	
Doctor · Pharmacy	
Claim or reference numbers	

Official numbers (checked November 2026)

Medicare	1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227)
Social Security	1-800-772-1213
DOJ Elder Fraud Hotline	1-833-FRAUD-11 (1-833-372-8311)
AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline	1-877-908-3360
Report fraud (FTC)	ReportFraud.ftc.gov
Identity theft recovery plan	IdentityTheft.gov
Internet crime (FBI)	ic3.gov
Eldercare Locator (local help, Adult Protective Services)	1-800-677-1116

WATCH FOR · ACT FAST

Warning signs, and if it happens

Signs a parent may be in a scam right now

- Secretive about calls, texts or a new online friend
- Buying gift cards, or several at once
- Large or unusual withdrawals, wires or Bitcoin ATM visits
- Asking you how to use a payment app or crypto
- Unopened bills, new credit cards they didn't ask for
- A "friend" or "advisor" you've never met who's suddenly important
- Anxious when the phone rings, or on long calls they won't explain
- Remote-access apps installed on their computer

If money has gone: the first hour

1. **Say it first:** "It's not your fault. Let's fix what we can."
2. **Call the bank or card issuer** on the number on the card. Ask them to stop or recall the payment and flag the account.
3. **Gift cards or payment app?** Call the gift card company or app right away with the receipt.
4. **Change passwords**, email first, from a device the scammer never touched. Remove any remote-access app.
5. **Freeze credit** if personal details were shared.
6. **Report** at ReportFraud.ftc.gov and ic3.gov, and call the Elder Fraud Hotline for help with next steps.
7. **Write everything down**: times, amounts, names, numbers, reference numbers.

Then expect the second scam. Anyone offering to recover the money for a fee, including people claiming to be lawyers, the FBI or the FTC, is very likely another scammer. Real agencies don't charge to help.

EVERY MONTH · 10 MINUTES

Monthly check-in tracker

A short call or visit once a month. Ask the five questions, tick the month, note anything to follow up.

1. "Any strange calls, texts or emails this month?"
2. "Did anyone ask you for money, a code or your details?"
3. "Anything new on the phone or computer you weren't sure about?"
4. "Shall we glance at the bank alerts together?"
5. "Do you still remember our safe word?"

Month	Done	Notes / follow-up
Jan		Get IRS IP PIN
Feb		
Mar		
Apr		Check credit reports
May		
Jun		
Jul		
Aug		Check credit reports
Sep		
Oct		Medicare open enrollment starts: no plan sales by phone
Nov		Holiday shopping and charity calls
Dec		Check credit reports · redo Visit 3 practice

CUT OUT · KEEP BY THE PHONE

Before you pay anyone

1. **Is it urgent, secret, or a strange way to pay?** Two of three: hang up.
2. **Call back** on a number you look up yourself, never the one they give you.
3. **No** gift cards, wires, crypto, Bitcoin ATMs, cash by courier, or payment apps to strangers.
4. **Never read a code** to anyone who contacted you.
5. **Call your trusted person** first.

My trusted person: _____

Phone: _____

"I don't make decisions about money on the phone. I'll call you back."

SOURCES · NOTES

Sources and fine print

- FTC: Pass It On; scams against older adults; imposter, tech support, romance and grandparent scams (consumer.ftc.gov)
- FBI IC3: Elder Fraud Report and public service announcements, including the family secret word advice (ic3.gov)
- FINRA Rule 4512 and the Trusted Contact Person (finra.org)
- CFPB: resources for older adults; trusted contacts and powers of attorney (consumerfinance.gov)
- Social Security Administration and Medicare: how they contact you (ssa.gov, medicare.gov)
- IRS: Identity Protection PIN; how the IRS contacts you (irs.gov)
- US DOJ Elder Justice Initiative: National Elder Fraud Hotline (justice.gov/elderjustice)
- Credit freezes: Equifax, Experian, TransUnion; NCTUE; ChexSystems; OptOutPrescreen.com

Want the family version too? Our **Family Scam-Proofing Kit** ($9) covers kids' credit freezes and a whole-family meeting. Bought this guide first? Reply to your receipt and we'll send a code for it.

Run a small business or a team? Our **Scam Awareness Training Pack** ($99) gives you a ready-to-run 45-minute session for staff: slides with speaker notes, scenarios, a quiz and certificates.

General education, not legal or financial advice. No guide can promise someone will never be scammed; this one helps families slow down and check. Phone menus differ by device and change with updates; follow the current wording on the screen. Phone numbers and websites checked November 2026; confirm with the official source. All example calls, names and numbers are fictional composites. Personal use within one family; please don't resell or share the file publicly.